

What students told us

The submitted packet contains 25 response sheets. Twelve use the focused availability questions, while 13 cover meal-plan preferences. The two groups support different claims and remain separate in this document.

Five ideas we considered

Real-time food availability

Show whether items and stations are available, low stock, or sold out.

Dining hours and service status

Show separate hours and current status for kitchens and counters.

Meal-plan rollover

Let unused money roll over and show the remaining balance.

Customizable meal plans

Offer dollar-balance, set-meal, or combined plan options.

Dining alerts

Notify students when an item, station, or service becomes unavailable.

What happened to students

Several students learned about a change only after reaching the counter, seeing an empty case, or reading a paper sign. The website or menu they checked beforehand did not show the update.

- A cafe was open, but its kitchen was closed. One participant spent about \$18 and waited roughly 40 minutes for delivery to the lab.
- An empty grab-and-go case caused one participant to take a 25-minute detour across campus for pizza.
- When the ribs were sold out, one participant spent about \$6 extra on a snack and waited until after class for a full meal.
- Sold-out soup, missing sandwiches, unavailable oat milk, cleared stations, and equipment or service changes caused students to choose something else.

Posted hours or menus matched reality in some interviews. The project therefore focuses on changes that normal menu and hours pages may not show, rather than replacing information that already works.

How we ran the interviews

The focused protocol asked about the last time a participant checked a menu or hours, what was available on arrival, the most recent surprise, what happened next, and the time or money involved.

- Ask about recent behavior and specific experiences instead of pitching a solution.
- Record repeated problems, workarounds, consequences, and cases where existing information was correct.
- Do not record without consent, and identify participants by a role or descriptor instead of a full name.

Why we chose this problem

The issue appeared in several focused interviews and had specific time, cost, and meal consequences. The team chose to test a system that lets students check the current status of dining items, stations, kitchens, counters, and temporary service changes before walking to a location.